



# Glitter of FAITH

An ambitious project aims at covering the Tirumala temple entirely with gold, using the donations of the faithful and not the resources of the world's wealthiest Hindu shrine

**| By Amarnath K. Menon |**

**A** Golden Age is about to dawn on the Tirumala temple. Karnataka Tourism Minister and Bellary mine baron Gali Janardhan Reddy's recent donation of a Rs 42-crore diamond-studded crown to the reigning deity, the biggest donation to Lord Venkateswara at Tirumala since the Vijayanagara kings 400 years ago, was only a sign of things to come. A massive scheme called the Ananda Nilayam Anantha Swarnamyam proj-

ect is now underway to cover the entire temple in gold.

The project, an exclusive donation scheme to gold-plate the richest Hindu shrine in the world, will create a glittering rival to the Golden Temple at Amritsar and the Sripuram Temple at Vellore. In the first phase, the outer and inner walls of the sanctum sanctorum, the Ananda Nilayam, will be plated with 300 kg of gold. The walls are engraved with historic inscriptions and intricate motifs. "Since the Sripuram golden temple draws a large number of devotees, we decided

to provide the most popular and richest Hindu shrine, the abode of Lord Venkateswara, with a much brighter glow," says Tirumala-Tirupathi Devasthanams (TTD) chairman Dalavai Krishnaswamy Adikesavulu, who was the wealthiest member of the last Lok Sabha.

Work on the outer walls of the Ananda Nilayam will be completed by March 2010. The TTD, which is providing all the material, has commissioned jewellers Nikhil Metal Arts and Crafts in Tirupati and Gnanam Enterprises in Kochi for the project.